



**Doubtful at the back:** Gurpreet, who captained India against Syria, has been a dependable presence between the sticks on countless occasions over the years. However, his recent performances for both club and country have shown signs of rust

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half to settle is a luxury India cannot afford, especially against more challenging teams. A slow start ultimately harmed India, and the positive glimpses were overshadowed.

### The need to experiment

One could argue this tournament's main purpose was to help Manolo get a better idea of his players, which would aid in implementing his system and finding the right combination of players. In Indian club football, Manolo's tactical versatility has been lauded, with the manager showing a penchant for experimenting, in contrast to former manager Igor Stimac's rigidity and refusal to venture out of his comfort zone.

Manolo gave a glimpse of his experimenting in the tournament decider against Syria. Moving away

from his preferred 4-2-3-1 formation, he opted for the classic 4-4-2. But the surprise element lay in the Spaniard choosing Sahal Abdul Samad as the second striker alongside Manvir. Despite Sahal's finishing abilities, he thrives in midfield, with his preferred position being as a central attacking midfielder, or what some would call the 'No.10 role.' Even though the Mohun Bagan Super Giant midfielder registered a shot on target, he looked uncomfortable with his off-the-ball movement and positioning, playing as the second striker. Whether the change was desirable is debatable, but it's certain this won't be the last time Manolo turns heads with his team selection.

### Failed flank play

India arguably has some of its most talented and promising players operating on the flanks, like Lallianzuala Chhangte, Liston Colaco, and Nandhakumar Sekar. This works to Manolo's benefit, as his system relies heavily on wingers to create attacks in the final third. It was no different in the Intercontinental Cup, as most of India's attacks came from the flanks. However, what faltered was the final ball.

A pattern visible against both Mauritius and Syria was the absence of direct wingers who could service the striker inside the box. While Chhangte is the only player who deserves a mention for trying, overall, India's crossing inside the box was poor, with most attempts being intercepted or blocked. Service was scarce, leaving the striker pleading for more.

### Knowing when to shoot

It is not just about shooting but knowing when to shoot — a common adage in basic football philosophies — which India failed to adhere to. The Blue Tigers' inability to carve out substantial chances led to futile shots reeking of impatience. Against Mauritius, India registered 10 shots, but only one was on target. Against Syria, it finished the contest with 18 shots, with just five on target. This is a crucial aspect Manolo needs to address with his team, particularly the forwards, about what to do when a good shooting position is not available.

### Composure at the back

Despite the goalless draw against Mauritius, Manolo praised the centre-back pairing of Chinglesana Singh and Rahul Bheke, saying it was one of the few positives from the match. However, a more challenging opponent like Syria exposed glaring issues in India's backline that need addressing.

There was a complete lack of communication among India's defenders against the Eagles of Qasioun, with no one understanding their roles clearly. Fullbacks Subhasish Bose and Nikhil Poojary rarely made overlaps to aid their attackers and, when they did, were too slow to track back when Syria launched counter-attacks.

One prime example of India's defensive miscommunication is the events leading to Mahmoud Alaswad's opening goal for Syria in the seventh minute. After successfully blocking the initial shot from inside the box, India's backline had plenty of time to clear the ball. But the players looked at each other, unsure of what